FUTUREREADY NYC · NYCPS OFFICE OF STUDENT PATHWAYS

RECRUITMENT & RETENTION PLAYBOOK

What schools must do, grade by grade.
When to do it. How to know it worked.

FUTURE READY NYC

NYC Student Pathways

2026 · FUTUREREADY NYC · VERSION 3

RECRUITMENT & RETENTION PLAYBOOK

WHAT THIS PLAYBOOK IS FOR

This playbook guides school staff through what to do — grade by grade — to build a full, equitable FRNYC cohort and retain students through credential completion. FRNYC places students into career pathways combining Work-Based Learning (WBL), college-credit coursework (ECC), and industry credentials before graduation. Enrollment officially begins in 10th grade; 9th grade is for exploration and interest alignment.

WHO THIS IS FOR

- **FRNYC Coordinators** — manage the full cycle from awareness to completion
- **School Counselors** — identify students, reconcile conflicts, support equitable access
- **APs of Instruction** — priority-schedule pathway classes; lead end-of-year debrief
- **Pathway Teachers** — deliver CCI coursework; connect students to WBL experiences

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE IN SCHOOLS — 5 CORE PRINCIPLES OF RECRUITMENT

1. TIMING (AWARENESS → COMMITMENT)
Recruitment is year-round, starting before students enter high school. Schools that delay until 10th grade struggle to enroll genuinely interested students. Strong programs begin in 8th grade and build through 9th.

2. INTEGRATION (EXPOSURE → EXPERIENCE)
Programs that operate as separate add-ons struggle with both recruitment and retention. Programs embedded in advisory, courses, and school culture see stronger enrollment and persistence.

3. SOCIAL PROOF (AWARENESS → EXPOSURE)
Students are most influenced by other students. Peer-to-peer communication builds trust, makes pathways feel real, and increases interest and enrollment.

4. RELEVANCE (EXPOSURE → COMMITMENT)
Students enroll and stay when they understand what they will do, what they will gain, and how it connects to their future. Concrete examples outperform abstract language like "career readiness."

5. EQUITY (ALL STAGES)
Students with disabilities and multilingual learners are often underrepresented due to structural barriers — not lack of interest. Strong programs track representation, identify barriers, and address them before they become attrition. See the Equity Checklist on page 5.

MILESTONES BY GRADE — KEY CHECKPOINTS

GRADE	MILESTONE	BY WHEN
8th	Feature FRNYC at open house with student ambassadors; begin feeder school outreach	*Fall–Spring*
9th	Interest survey deployed to every 9th grader — responses required (Yes / No / Maybe)	*End of March*
9th	1:1 meetings with interested students using survey responses; cohort confirmed	*April*
9th	FRNYC orientation + parent session for rising 10th graders	*By May*
10th	KIMS enrollment confirmed — ECC data locked for accountability	*October 1*
12th	ECC completion push active; ambassador recruitment underway	*Jan–April*
All	End-of-year debrief complete before staff leave for summer	*Before June 30*

> *"Lead with what students get — a real-world WBL experience (internship, job shadow, or workplace simulation), college credit, or an industry-recognized credential before graduation — not with what FRNYC is or does."*

AWARENESS & OUTREACH

8TH GRADE

8

Goal: 8th graders and their families know your school is a FRNYC school — and are interested enough to choose it.

	HOW TO DO IT	WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE
Promote FRNYC on all school materials	▫ Add "Future Ready NYC" to website, flyers, and social posts — use FRNYC logos from OSP ▫ Lead with outcomes students earn: ECC credits, WBL experience, industry credentials	*Visitors know you're a FRNYC school before they arrive*
Run ambassador-led open house	▫ Brief 2–3 FRNYC students using the Ambassador Script (Student Ambassador Toolkit) ▫ Assign to small groups — conversation beats a stage presentation	*8th graders hear a concrete outcome from a current FRNYC student*
Feeder school outreach + invite to FRNYC event	▫ Contact 3–5 feeder school counselors; offer campus tour or ambassador visit (cold outreach script in Student Ambassador Toolkit) ▫ Invite prospective 8th graders to a student showcase or career fair — no application required	*2+ feeder visits done; prospective students see FRNYC in action*

Year 0: Start with your own students first. Identify 2–3 excited 10th or 11th graders and prepare them as ambassadors before any external outreach — teach each one to share: one concrete outcome they earned, one thing they learned in the program, and why they chose this pathway. That's the whole script. They are your most powerful recruitment asset.

EXPLORATION & INTEREST ALIGNMENT

9TH GRADE

9

Goal: Every 9th grader explores career options and can say whether FRNYC fits. Cohort confirmed and orientation done before end of year.

	HOW TO DO IT	WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE
Career Explorations for all 9th graders, fall–spring	▫ Cover multiple career areas, not only FRNYC — ask: "Which connects to something you care about?" ▫ By end of the unit, each student names one career area that interests them and one reason why; note who follows up about FRNYC	*Students can say whether FRNYC fits their interests*
Ambassador touchpoints + parent-student panel	▫ Ambassador visits to 9th grade advisories — fall and spring (Advisory Slide Deck, Student Ambassador Toolkit) ▫ One parent-student panel per year — FRNYC students share what they've done; parents hear directly and ask questions	*Every 9th grader has 2+ direct FRNYC exposures by March*
Interest survey — all 9th graders, March	▫ Google Form to every 9th grader — required (Yes / No / Maybe); each student explains their choice in 1–2 sentences ▫ Coordinator follows up with non-responders within 5 days	*100% response rate; sorted Yes / No / Maybe list by end of March*
1:1 meetings in April → orientation by May	▫ April: 1:1 with each interested student; survey response is the agenda; conflicts get a conversation, not exclusion ▫ By May: rising 10th graders meet their teacher and cohort; parent session covers what students will earn and key dates	*Rising 10th graders enter September knowing their pathway, cohort, and teacher*

Move the survey to March, not May. This gives you April for 1:1 conversations and time to finish orientation before year-end. "Maybe" triggers a follow-up, not an exclusion.

COHORT LAUNCH & DEEP ENGAGEMENT

10TH GRADE

10

Goal: Students are officially welcomed into FRNYC as a cohort. WBL experiences align with CCI coursework. Peer community and identity form.

	HOW TO DO IT	*WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE*
Launch cohort + build monthly community cadence	▫ Inaugural FRNYC event (assembly or cohort lunch) — welcome rising 10th graders by name; older students share one thing they've done or earned ▫ Monthly FRNYC community time — 30–60 min during advisory, lunch, or after school (Cohort Meeting Guide, Cohort Toolkit) ▫ If students span multiple CCI sections, use cohort time to unite them — that cross-section peer network is the primary retention driver	*Students feel visible and valued; peers become their support network*
Align WBL with CCI via intermediary partner	▫ Share the CCI course overview with your WBL intermediary partner (assigned by OSP) at semester start — they arrange all placements; schools do not place students directly ▫ Confirm 100% of students have a WBL placement aligned to their pathway by October	*Every student sees the connection between coursework and real-world experience*
Family milestone events each semester	▫ One family event per semester — showcase, career panel, or Career Discovery Week; answer four questions: What will my student earn? What skills? What real-world experience? What's the post-graduation benefit? ▫ Translate all materials into the top 3 home languages of the school	*Parents can describe what their student is earning in the program*

SUPPORTIVE SERVICES & POST-SECONDARY PLANNING

11TH GRADE

11

Goal: Academic supports that help students meet ECC eligibility requirements are scheduled into the school day — not offered as optional add-ons. Every student builds a post-secondary plan grounded in their FRNYC experience.

	HOW TO DO IT	*WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE*
Build ECC supports into the schedule	▫ Audit enrollment — identify who needs support to meet ECC eligibility requirements (placement scores, GPA, or prerequisites set by the ECC partner); AP schedules tutoring or Regents prep inside the school day ▫ Coordinate all deadlines directly with the ECC partner institution delivering the course	*Every student has a clear path to ECC eligibility, with a support plan if needed*
Structured touchpoints + early intervention	▫ 2+ structured group sessions per year connecting CCI and WBL work to post-graduation goals; keep attendance and flag anyone who misses 2+ ▫ Warning: 3+ missed sessions, declining CCI/ECC grades, or expressed disinterest → 1:1 within 1 week; document what was discussed, what the student commits to, and by when	*No student exits without a documented conversation first*
Post-secondary planning from FRNYC experience	▫ Ask each student: "Based on your FRNYC work, what do you want after graduation?" — use WBL, CCI, and ECC as the starting point ▫ Before spring semester ends, document each student's plan: WBL experiences, ECC courses completed, and intended next step (college, career, or both) — use Post-Secondary Planning Template from OSP	*Every student has a documented post-secondary intention referencing their FRNYC experience*

COMPLETION & AMBASSADOR PIPELINE

12TH GRADE

12

Goal: Every enrolled student earns their credential before graduation. Completers become next year's ambassadors. The cycle renews.

	HOW TO DO IT	*WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE*
KIMS review — September	▫ Pull each student's ECC record from KIMS — on-track vs. needs-support; data not in KIMS won't count toward accountability ▫ By October 1: every at-risk student has a written completion plan — Coordinator tracks, Principal is accountable	*Every student's ECC status is known by October 1*
ECC partner coordination	▫ Name a direct contact at the ECC partner institution; know all enrollment, withdrawal, and grade reporting deadlines ▫ When a student is struggling, contact the ECC liaison directly — don't wait for grades; ask about support or withdrawal options before mid-semester, when options narrow	*No credit lost due to a missed administrative deadline*
Completion push (Jan–Apr) + ambassador recruitment	▫ January: check KIMS for ECC progress; weekly check-ins for anyone behind — name exactly what to complete and by when ▫ Recruit 3–5 completing seniors as ambassadors — ask directly; their role: open house, advisory visits, share their FRNYC experience	*90%+ earn credential before graduation; 3+ ambassadors confirmed*
End-of-year debrief before staff leave	▫ Coordinator + AP + Counselor: review % who completed, where drop-offs occurred, 3 specific changes for next cycle ▫ File the debrief before June 30 — findings shape next fall's open house messaging and which feeder schools to prioritize	*Written debrief on file; 3 specific changes identified for next year*

EQUITY CHECKLIST — SWD & MLL ACCESS

Review each barrier below at enrollment and again at mid-year — check whether it applies to your school. Underrepresentation is a structural problem — not a preferences problem.

BARRIER TO WATCH FOR	WHAT TO DO
IEP mandated services or pull-out schedules create scheduling conflicts that block SWD students from the cohort — often without anyone flagging it	Cross-reference the "Yes"/"Maybe" survey list with the master schedule before the cohort is finalized. Students blocked by scheduling get a 1:1 conversation to explore alternatives — period swaps, modified pull-out schedules, or an alternate CCI section. Flag to the AP before the cohort is finalized.
Open house materials, interest survey, and pathway descriptions are English-only	Translate all core materials (open house flyer, interest survey, orientation communication) into the top 3 home languages of your school — request translation support from the ENL department or your network office. Recruit bilingual student ambassadors to represent those languages.
ECC courses at partner colleges often require college-level placement in math or English — SWD and MLL students may qualify via different pathways but get screened out by how prerequisites are applied	Audit prerequisite lists annually. Identify what is a confirmed requirement set by the partner institution vs. an internal assumption that can be challenged. Escalate structural barriers to your AP and OSP.
SWD / MLL enrollment in FRNYC is significantly below their share of the school population	Set an explicit equity target before each cycle — for example: if SWD students are 20% of the 9th grade, aim for 20% of the FRNYC cohort. Actively recruit SWD and MLL students early, knowing some may later face scheduling barriers, so that after any drop-off their share of the cohort still reflects the school population. Escalate significant gaps to school leadership and OSP before October 1.